

PROJECTORS

Watching a movie, giving a presentation, or simply huge-screen gaming—everything is possible on a projector today, which is now within the reach of the general consumer. We did see changes in this category as compared to last year. 2006 was dominated by SVGA projectors (capable of 800 x 600), whereas this time round, the picture was different, with XGA projectors (capable of 1024 x 768) being the dominant breed. We've also seen the entry of native HD (720p) projectors for the home theatre audience. Falling prices add to the attraction of a projector, and a large LCD or Plasma screen just cannot capture the same cinematic experience.

XGA PROJECTORS

The Reigning Champion

Acer PD726W

The Acer PD726W was perhaps the best-looking of the projectors we tested last year. A sober black-and-silver colour tone and rugged build quality make it really appealing. Connectivity options are endless, with Component, S-Video, RCA, D-Sub, DVI, and even HDMI thrown in—and there's network connectivity via RJ45 and Wi-Fi. It is also possible to interface with the device through RS-232 and USB (both USB A and B type connects are provided in the package). The menu interface is easy. It allows you to specify an IP address to which a message can be automatically sent in case something goes wrong.

The Contender

NEC NP1000

NEC's NP1000 showed signs of excellence, with an ANSI brightness of 3400 lumens and an actual static contrast ratio of 800:1. The



NP 1000 is very good for home and professional use alike. It has got five bayonet lenses inside that can vary from 30 to 500 inches, offering an amazing viewing experience when placed at a distance of 2.5 to 68.5 feet from the screen. It offers both vertical and horizontal lens shift, allowing nearly limitless projector placement. This projector

also offers integrated high speed wireless LAN IEEE 802.11b/g via an optional wireless card. It has presentation, broadcast, data conferencing and training mode, that gives the user, the flexibility for just about any wireless application. Remote diagnostics features enable the monitoring of the status and adjustment of different functions of the projectors remotely over a network, making it perfect for any corporation. The NP1000 features Eco-mode technology, that increases the lamp-life by at least 50 per cent. To add to this, the cooling fan continues to run for some time even after the power is disconnected and the in-built sensors protect the lamp and projector from overheating. There are also some security features such as logo lock, password protection cabinet control lock which let you prevent anyone from changing the its settings. Its price of Rs 1,20,000 does put it into the high-end bracket as far as affordability goes.

The Award

Acer PD726W

The Acer PD726W has a very good brightness rating spec—3700 lumens. Coupled with a high contrast ratio (2500:1), the PD726W is very much a multimedia aficionado's dream. When we did the 256-shade intensity screen calibration, we encountered smooth transitions between the shades. It performed very well in the presentation tests; text reproduction was



sharp. While halos did appear around extremely light colours, they would disappear by tuning the brightness and contrast. This is a great movie projector with sharp image rendition and great contrast, and a great projector for big-screen gaming and movies alike. Without a shadow of doubt, this is the only projector that can win Zero1—absolutely no hesitation whatsoever!

SPEAKER SETS

PC sound has matured over the past decade to such an extent that it gives hi-fi sets a run for their money. This has become possible due to advancements in PC sound cards, and more so because the PC speakers of today are much better than those of a few years ago.

2.1 sets are considered entry-level, though the more expensive 2.1 sets are audiophile-class. 5.1 sets are better for multi-channel scenarios such as games and DVD movies.

2.1 SPEAKER SETS

The Reigning Champion

Altec Lansing ATP3

These sleek black speakers will look good on any desktop. They are also built tough. There are controls for Bass, Treble, and Volume. The large, 6.5-inch woofer produces rich bass, and each of the satellites has two 1.1-inch tweeters and a 3-inch driver. The woofer is 18 W RMS, while the satellites are 12 W (combined)—more than what might be expected of a 2.1 set. The power adapter is built into the speakers.

The Contender

Altec Lansing FX4021

As with the ATP3, build quality is rugged. There are two 5.25-inch drivers in isobaric configuration to provide double the amount of bass. The satellites have 40 mm and 18 mm drivers to handle a higher range of frequencies. It comes with metal stands that add to the aesthetic appeal. There's a wired as well as a wireless remote control. Overall performance was good, and the bass stood out. This set is priced a little on the higher side—Rs 7,500.

The Award

Altec Lansing ATP3

The Altec Lansing ATP3 is strong in all areas of the audio spectrum, meaning both Western and Indian music will sound good. Whether it's



games or movies, these speakers will not disappoint. Even with a relatively high price tag of Rs 3,400, these speakers are too good not to be awarded the Zero1 in the 2.1 category!

5.1 SPEAKER SETS

The Reigning Champion

Artis S6600R / FM

The Artis S6600R/FM set is unique: it has not only FM radio, but also AM—an inexpensive, very useful add-on. Though they sport a chrome finish, the speakers aren't gaudy. There is a discrete amplifier box with all the controls. The full-featured wireless remote lets you control everything including the radio and individual channel volumes. In addition to the 5.1-channel input, there is also a stereo auxiliary input to let you connect stereo audio sources.

The Contenders

Artis X10 Mini

Built very well, the Artis X10 Mini (Rs 12,000) comes with nice, sturdy steel stands for rear speakers to elevate them to the ear-level of the listener. The satellites have veils with grilles behind, giving the drivers some extra protection. The subwoofer is made of wood; wood grains are visible on the exterior, giving it a classy look. The provided cables are colour-coded, and are of exceptionally good quality. The strong bass never drowned out the treble, and we could hear every bit of detail even with the bass at full throttle. Cranking up the volume and bass levels did not seem to do any damage to the sound quality.

The Award

Artis S6600R / FM

As far as audio quality is concerned, the Artis S6600R / FM is strong throughout the spectrum—treble in particular. In our gaming and DVD movie tests, it reproduced directional sound with great accuracy and clarity. The Artis S6600R / FM is an all-in-one package at a very good price of Rs 8,500; it wins the Zero1 award in the 5.1 category.

